

Caring for Your Mental Health

National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) — Full webpage content organized into a printable PDF

Overview

Mental health includes emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It is more than the absence of a mental illness—it's essential to your overall health and quality of life. Self-care can play a role in maintaining your mental health and help support your treatment and recovery if you have a mental illness.

How can I take care of my mental health?

Self-care means taking the time to do things that help you live well and improve both your physical health and mental health. This can help you manage stress, lower your risk of illness, and increase your energy. Even small acts of self-care in your daily life can have a big impact.

Here are some self-care tips:

- **Get regular exercise.** Just 30 minutes of walking every day can boost your mood and improve your health. Small amounts of exercise add up, so don't be discouraged if you can't do 30 minutes at one time.
- **Eat healthy, regular meals and stay hydrated.** A balanced diet and plenty of water can improve your energy and focus throughout the day. Pay attention to your intake of caffeine and alcohol and how they affect your mood and well-being—for some, decreasing caffeine and alcohol consumption can be helpful.
- **Make sleep a priority.** Stick to a schedule, and make sure you're getting enough sleep. Blue light from devices and screens can make it harder to fall asleep, so reduce blue light exposure from your phone or computer before bedtime.
- **Try a relaxing activity.** Explore relaxation or wellness programs or apps, which may incorporate meditation, muscle relaxation, or breathing exercises. Schedule regular times for these and other healthy activities you enjoy, such as listening to music, reading, spending time in nature, and engaging in low-stress hobbies.
- **Set goals and priorities.** Decide what must get done now and what can wait. Learn to say "no" to new tasks if you start to feel like you're taking on too much. Try to appreciate what you have accomplished at the end of the day.
- **Practice gratitude.** Remind yourself daily of things you are grateful for. Be specific. Write them down or replay them in your mind.
- **Focus on positivity.** Identify and challenge your negative and unhelpful thoughts.
- **Stay connected.** Reach out to friends or family members who can provide emotional support and practical help.

Self-care looks different for everyone, and it is important to find what you need and enjoy. It may take trial and error to discover what works best for you.

Learn more: Healthy practices for your mind and body — NIH.

When should I seek professional help?

Seek professional help if you are experiencing severe or distressing symptoms that have lasted 2 weeks or more, such as:

- Difficulty sleeping

- Changes in appetite or unplanned weight changes
- Difficulty getting out of bed in the morning because of mood
- Difficulty concentrating
- Loss of interest in things you usually find enjoyable
- Inability to complete usual tasks and activities
- Feelings of irritability, frustration, or restlessness

How can I find help?

If you have concerns about your mental health, talk to a primary care provider. They can refer you to a qualified mental health professional, such as a psychologist, psychiatrist, or clinical social worker, who can help you figure out the next steps. NIMH also provides tips for talking with a health care provider about your mental health.

You can learn more about getting help on the NIMH website. You can also learn about finding support and locating mental health services in your area on the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) website.

If you or someone you know is struggling or having thoughts of suicide: NIMH's U.S.-specific guidance says to call or text the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline at 988 or chat through 988lifeline.org. The service is confidential, free, and available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. In life-threatening situations, call 911.

Suicide is preventable. NIMH links to information about warning signs of suicide and action steps for helping someone in emotional distress.

Featured videos

GREAT: Helpful Practices to Manage Stress and Anxiety. Learn about helpful practices to manage stress and anxiety. GREAT was developed by Dr. Krystal Lewis, a licensed clinical psychologist at NIMH.

Mental Health Minute: Stress and Anxiety in Adolescents. A 60-second mental health resource about stress and anxiety in adolescents.

Featured fact sheets

The webpage provides a link to additional NIMH featured fact sheets.

Learn more

- **NIH Wellness Toolkits:** NIH provides toolkits with strategies for improving emotional health and social health.
- **MedlinePlus: How to Improve Mental Health:** MedlinePlus provides health information and tips for improving mental health.
- **CDC: Emotional Well-Being:** CDC provides information on how to cope with stress and promote social connectedness.
- **SAMHSA: How to Cope:** SAMHSA offers tips for taking care of your well-being and connecting with others for support.
- **VA Office of Mental Health: Veteran Training:** VA offers free, confidential courses to help veterans enhance their mental health and life skills.

Page information

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NIMH Resources: Health Topics; Brochures and Fact Sheets; Contact Us; Información en español.

Policies and Notices: Privacy Policy; Website Policies; FOIA; Accessibility; HHS Vulnerability Disclosure.

Federal Resources: National Institutes of Health (NIH); NIH Virtual Tour; U.S. Department of Health and Human Services; USA.gov.

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